
Premier League: 10 talking points from the weekend's action

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Guardiola and Arteta opt for muscle

Pep Guardiola becomes ever more the traditional English football man. As his [Manchester City](#) stay extends to 10 seasons, he relies ever more on the principle that big players can win big matches. Hence his late-career conversion to employing a wrecking ball striker in the peerless Erling Haaland. As for his former assistant Mikel Arteta, Arsenal looked stuck in the weeds of over-thinking. Benching Eberechi Eze, who tortured City in last season's FA Cup final, till half-time was just too clever by half. Arteta's recent talk of using rugby strategy, of thinking of substitutes as finishers, in the style of South Africa's "bomb squad" is all very well. Even if the substitute Gabriel Martinelli scored the equaliser from an Eze long ball, a talented, capable squad playing one-dimensional fare is far less explicable. This is not the City who previously dominated the Premier League. They showed their own limitations, particularly once Haaland, brilliant as attacker and defender, was removed. **John Brewin**

Match report: [Arsenal 1-1 Manchester City](#)

Grealish gives Liverpool a scare

Jack Grealish knows he has a point to prove at [Everton](#). After being cast aside at Manchester City and allowed to depart on loan, the winger's career faced questions. He took the opportunity to join an Everton side heading into a new era at Hill Dickinson Stadium and with a new, more attacking strategy under David Moyes. Having someone of Grealish's quality almost feels like a luxury at a club more accustomed to finishing in the bottom half but the England international is backing up his natural ability with hard work. He had the better of Conor Bradley for much of the Merseyside derby, helped set up the Everton goal and was repeatedly fouled as Liverpool did what they could to stop him. With an international break not too far away, Grealish will once more be a serious contender for a call-up. It would be merited. **Will Unwin**

Match report: [Liverpool 2-1 Everton](#)

Shaw accepts Keane criticism

In the aftermath of victory over Chelsea, Luke Shaw admitted that Roy Keane's criticism of him that "he doesn't even want to tackle" during Manchester United's 3-0 defeat at Manchester City hurts. The defender said: "Sometimes you have to take it on the chin. I wasn't at my level at all. I don't need Roy Keane to tell me. The most important thing is knowing how good I can be. The manager knows that. The managers who I played with in the past know that. I'm always in the team and I'm always playing, so there must be something that the managers believe in. I'm not getting any younger now and I need to be consistent." **Jamie Jackson**

Match report: [Manchester United 2-1 Chelsea](#)

Exasperated Emery looks for identity

Unai Emery had seen enough. With 30 seconds remaining Aston Villa's manager stormed down the tunnel, presumably in search of his side's missing identity. No matter that Matty Cash had scored Villa's first [Premier League](#) goal of the season, a 1-1 draw against a Sunderland side reduced to 10 men when Reinildo was sent off for violent conduct in the 33rd minute was not good enough for the Spaniard. "We are not like a team we want to be," said Emery. "I'm disappointed. We need to get our confidence back, collectively and as individuals. My worry is that we are not playing with our identity." If something is wrong at Villa Park, Régis Le Bris is doing an awful lot right at Sunderland. This was the promoted side's eighth point from five games and Le Bris was evidently delighted by his supremely organised 10-men team's willingness "to suffer" before Wilson Isidor's equalising half-volley. **Louise Taylor**

Match report: [Sunderland 1-1 Aston Villa](#)

Brighton handle Baleba with care

Fabian Hürzeler removed Carlos Baleba at half-time after 45 minutes in which Tottenham dominated midfield but conceded two well-taken Brighton goals. The explanation given was not injury but fatigue. Hürzeler proceeded to deliver a sermon on the pitfalls of husbanding talent when players become subject to transfer speculation. Baleba was linked during the summer transfer window with a £100m-plus move to Manchester United. "When a young boy reads there is interest from Manchester United with a big, big offer, it might affect him deep. Even if he's not saying: 'It affects me,' maybe deep inside of him there is something," said Brighton's manager. "It's also part of the development, to understand when you play well and a big club comes, to keep pushing, to stay humble, to stay at Brighton and to make the next step as a team." Baleba had lost possession eight times, completing just 17 passes. "There are waves in the development," said Hürzeler. "It's not always linear. He's not a machine." **John Brewin**

Match report: [Brighton 2-2 Tottenham](#)

Midfield leads West Ham's problems

It was obvious that West Ham had to fix their midfield last summer. It is absurd that they focus on other positions first, signing Mads Hermansen to be their new goalkeeper and replacing Emerson Palmieri with El Hadji Malick Diouf at left-back. Priorities were skewed. It was only after West Ham lost their first two games that they brought in new midfielders. Even then, though, Graham Potter and the club's recruitment chief, Kyle Macaulay, chose questionably. Mateus Fernandes has done well since joining from Southampton but Soungoutou Magassa has been restricted to two substitute appearances. The France Under-21d international has not played much senior football, is adapting to the English game and has joined a team short of leaders and quality. It is not fair to expect a 21-year-old to make an immediate impact. He has potential and may come good in the long run but he feels like a bonus signing. **Jacob Steinberg**

Match report: [West Ham 1-2 Crystal Palace](#)

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Newcastle a tough watch on travels

Newcastle supporters rack up plenty of mileage when travelling around the country every season. Down on the south coast on Sunday, they saw their team eke out a third successive 0-0 draw away from home, making it 270 minutes of goalless football on the road after stalemates at [Aston Villa](#) and Leeds. Across those trips to Elland Road and the Vitality Stadium, Newcastle mustered just 12 shots. Nick Woltemade, who looked so imposing on debut against Wolves at St James' Park, was kept quiet by Bafodé Diakité and Marcos Senesi in the middle of the Bournemouth defence. "That wasn't necessarily an easy watch all the way through but I think they can see the commitment from the players," Howe said, somewhat guardedly, after the game. **Billy Munday**

Match report: [Bournemouth 0-0 Newcastle](#)

Postecoglou plan is taking shape

After losing to Arsenal, Ange Postecoglou was asked when his trademark Ange-ball style might be discernible in his new [Nottingham Forest](#) team. "Wednesday," was the unequivocal answer from the straight-talking Australian. In reality, he was three days out. A much-changed Forest side collapsed to a chaotic late defeat at Swansea on the day in question. The players who turned out at Burnley on Saturday, however, exhibited exactly the kind of verve and vigour in attack that Postecoglou demands. He stressed there was still work ahead, especially around finishing, but believes already that Forest look "a different team" to the one he inherited from Nuno Espírito Santo. Forest are winless in three games under Postecoglou so far, but the early signs of progress are there. **Dominic Booth**

Match report: [Burnley 1-1 Nottingham Forest](#)

Wolves' bleak start continues

This time last season, Wolves had also failed to win any of their first five league matches, but the difference this time is the fixture list. Gary O'Neil could point towards the difficulty of a bruising set of opening fixtures as mitigation given their first five games were against teams who went on to finish in the top seven: [Arsenal](#), Chelsea, Nottingham Forest, Newcastle and Aston Villa. The schedule this season has been kind by comparison but Wolves are worse off, pointless after Leeds stormed to a comeback win at Molineux on Saturday. Wolves, also beaten by Manchester City, Bournemouth, Everton and Newcastle in the league this campaign, travel to Tottenham next weekend after a Carabao Cup third-round tie at home to David Moyes's side. "A win would give us confidence," Vítor Pereira said. "We need to improve, I need to improve." **Ben Fisher**

Match report: [Wolves 1-3 Leeds](#)

Sessegnon flourishing back home

It's easy to forget that Ryan Sessegnon is still only 25. The full-back emerged as a teen sensation in

2017-18, scoring 15 goals in the Championship on the way to promotion with [Fulham](#). His career has not been simple, blighted by injury and an inability to break through at Tottenham. After rejoining his childhood club last season he has been rebuilding and is starting to show what a player he is. Sessegnon has started every Premier League match so far this season and against Brentford he was a constant offensive threat, either driving with the ball or with his deliveries. An irresistible whipped cross tempted Ethan Pinnock into making contact and an own goal that sealed the game. His combination play with Alex Iwobi was key to the Cottagers' success. The result will reaffirm supporters' belief that Fulham can look upwards this season, something that – fingers crossed – will apply to Sessegnon personally too. **Paul MacInnes**

Match report: [Fulham 3-1 Brentford](#)

Pos	Team	P	GD	Pts
1	Liverpool	5	6	15
2	Arsenal	5	8	10
3	Tottenham Hotspur	5	7	10
4	AFC Bournemouth	5	1	10
5	Crystal Palace	5	4	9
6	Chelsea	5	5	8
7	Sunderland	5	2	8
8	Fulham	5	1	8
9	Man City	5	4	7
10	Everton	5	1	7
11	Man Utd	5	-2	7
12	Leeds	5	-3	7
13	Newcastle	5	0	6
14	Brighton	5	-2	5
15	Nottm Forest	5	-4	5
16	Burnley	5	-3	4
17	Brentford	5	-4	4
18	Aston Villa	5	-4	3
19	West Ham	5	-8	3
20	Wolverhampton	5	-9	0

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